between Blanc—the French word for 'white', which summarises the theme of that dining area—and Rose Bar, a space with garish red lighting and silver seats that are reminiscent of a 1980s supervillain lair.

There's a private dining area—'Verde' (French, again, for 'green'), and on the floor above, we're told (these areas aren't open to visitors as yet) will be 'Bawa Bar,' christened thus to pay homage to architect Geoffrey Bawa's tropical aesthetic, and another yacht deck-inspired bar, 'Nautica'. What any of these themes have to do with each other or the title of the place—'Neuma', which is Latin for 'Holy Spirit'—is anybody's guess. Even more befuddling is a sculpture near the stairs, a figure whose head is an amalgamation of soft toys in which Pikachu's face, somewhat controversially, rests between Tigger's legs.

The food, at least, is less mysterious. Simple titles tell you exactly what you're ordering: 'butter prawns', 'za'atar chicken', 'watermelon and asparagus salad'. The presentation of each dish is testimony to Chef Abhinav Sharma's artistry. The Harissa Cauliflower is a fantastic blend of flavours and the lamb shank is cooked to perfection. The avocado toast is pretty, if ordinary. Only one dish really disappoints: the 'potato boulangère', which, though tasty, is a portion of glorified aloo-tuk drizzled with mild chutney.

It doesn't seem to matter much anyway. Certainly, the ladies lunching there didn't seem too concerned about the influences that may have shaped the menu or the design of the place. They weren't there to spot celebrities either; they just seemed glad to have a new place to dine at after being homebound for so long. Would they return, though? Some, who made a beeline for "Karan Johar's new restaurant" as soon as it opened, told this reporter they felt it was expensive, but ordinary—like that avocado toast—meaning seconds are out of the question. "Bombay spoils you for choice," as one patron put it. Evidently, Karan Johar's superhit formula doesn't extend to restaurants just yet. ■

–Anjana Vaswani

MADE TO ORDER



With Bollywood stars at the helm, these restaurants certainly don't need any Michelin stars



PRIYANKA CHOPRA JONAS

Sona, New York

In March 2021, **Priyanka Chopra Jonas** joined the elite list of celebrities-turned-restaurateurs with the launch of her luxurious Indian restaurant, Sona, in New York. Though the property doesn't showcase any PC memorabilia, a private dining area within the sprawling rectangular property has been christened 'Mimi', because Priyanka's mother used to call her that when she was a little girl, saying she'd grow up to be another Mimi Rogers. Much talked about since the place opened, Chef Hari Nayak's menu includes familiar options—mutton cutlet, Awadhi gosht korma, halwa and Rajasthani jungle maas—but also dishes aimed at pleasing the American palate like butter roasted oysters, Gruyere cheese dosa and burrata tikka masala.
One of the most popular items here is the vada pav, which, New Yorkers are busy savouring for $14. i.e., **Rs 1,086!**



SHILPA SHETTY

Bastian, Mumbai

Actor **Shilpa Shetty's** name was a big draw when the Worli outpost of Bastian opened in 2020, in the gap between pandemic-related lockdowns. People enjoy the idea of supporting celebrities; plus, there's the adrenaline rush that comes with the possibility of capturing Insta-worthy pictures with the actor and/or her star friends. The tasteful interiors of the restaurant were an added perk. Almost two years after its launch, the restaurant is still packed. Ask regular patrons and they'll tell you what the secret sauce is: great food (and good music). Whether it's the teriyaki chicken, salmon carpaccio, the tuna poke bowl, the choice of cocktails or the selection of unusual desserts, nothing disappoints at Bastian.



ASHA BHOSLE

Asha's, Global chain

Did you know singer **Asha Bhosle** has an international chain of restaurants that serve Indian cuisine? Launched about 20 years ago, her restaurant chain Asha's has a presence in 18 cities, including Birmingham, Manchester, Doha, Manama and Dubai. Decorated with a modern aesthetic that doesn't hint at the owner's illustrious career, Asha's big attraction is the food. The recipes come straight from Asha's kitchen (except those from the tandoor). Few know that Bhosle is a talented chef. As a matter of fact, R.D. Burman and Bhosle used to compete with each other to see who could cook better.



DHARMENDRA

Garam Dharam, New Delhi

Garam Dharam looks exactly the way you'd imagine **Dharmendra's** restaurant to. Think a slightly upscale dhaba—with bright colours, cylindrical pillows on benches and a menu that delivers taste more than it does style. Located in New Delhi's Connaught Place, Garam Dharam stays true to Dharmendra's image. It's easy to picture the earthy actor digging into the Amritsari chicken, tawa seekh and shahi paneer and washing them all down with a glass of lassi. While it is starry here for sure, the prices, thankfully, aren't sky high.